## Rebuilding Saudi Arabia's research reputation

The news that Saudi Arabia has the highest rate of article retractions among large research-producing nations (see *Nature* **624**, 479; 2023) raises concerns about the credibility of the country's research. Swift action must be taken to avoid this issue hindering its scientific advancement.

Controls in institutions must be strengthened to ensure that the quality and ethical standards of research activities are met. Education on research ethics should be prioritized, and a reward system based on quality, not quantity, should be implemented (see M. Uddin & N. Khalaf Alharbi *Dig. Health* https://doi.org/mchh; 2023).

Actions to rebuild credibility could include implementing a post-publication peer-review system that allows full and transparent access to research data for validation, revision and replication. Such a system would help to avoid bias and favouritism in conventional journals, facilitate dynamic discussion and leverage international expert opinions.

Strengthened research protocols supported by the Saudi government and the help of specialist external advisers would provide better direction for researchers. Penalties for infringements would deter unethical practices and emphasize the importance of adhering to publication standards. Saudi Arabia has the potential to be a valuable member of the international research community, if it can show its commitment to resolving its current problems.

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